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Insights Beyond The Diagnosis

Why do we re-excise benign lesions

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Understanding the Rationale for Re-excision of Benign Lesions

For patients, the word benign often signals the end of concern. For dermatologists and pathologists, however, management decisions do not always end with a benign diagnosis. In certain situations, re-excision of a benign lesion may be appropriate and medically justified.

Common Reasons for Re-excision of Benign Lesions

Diagnostic Uncertainty

Some lesions are only partially sampled or show overlapping features with atypical or malignant processes. Additional tissue may be necessary to ensure an accurate diagnosis.

Risk of Local Recurrence

Some histologically benign tumors can recur repeatedly and become larger, more fibrotic, or more difficult to interpret clinically and histologically over time.

Locally Aggressive Behavior

Not all benign lesions behave innocently. Certain benign neoplasms may infiltrate surrounding tissue, distort anatomy, or cause functional or cosmetic problems.

Clinicopathologic Discordance

If the pathology findings do not fully match the lesion's clinical appearance or behavior, re-excision may help resolve lingering concerns.

Prevention of Future Diagnostic Confusion

Recurrent benign lesions may develop scarring, inflammation, cytologic atypia, or architectural distortion, complicating future interpretation and potentially mimicking malignancy.

Molecular and Biologic Considerations

Emerging research suggests that some recurrent benign tumors may undergo molecular and microenvironmental changes over time, including clonal selection, altered signaling pathways, and epigenetic changes that may favor persistence or increased proliferative behavior.

A benign diagnosis does not always mean a lesion is biologically inactive, clinically insignificant, or completely resolved. Re-excision decisions are often based on integrated clinicopathologic judgment aimed at achieving diagnostic certainty, reducing recurrence risk, preserving function and cosmesis, and optimizing long-term patient care.

"Questions or cases to discuss? We're always happy to review."

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